

Ohio River South Shore Trail Feasibility Study



September 2010 - **DRAFT**

Ohio River South Shore Trail Feasibility Study

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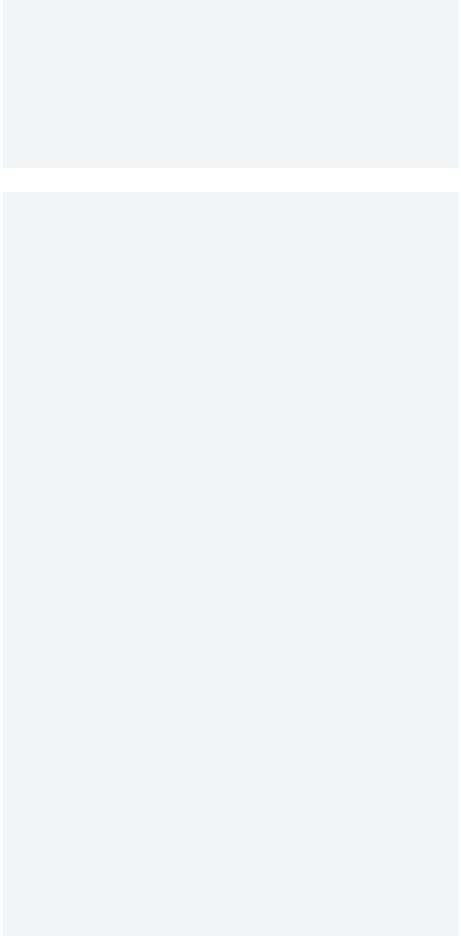
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This Feasibility Study was funded by the Pennsylvania Department of Conservation and Natural Resources and administered by the City of Aliquippa in partnership with Beaver County.

Ohio River South Shore Trail Feasibility Study

Page Table of Contents

iii-vi	Executive Summary
I.1-I.X	Chapter 1 Project Background, Public Planning Process and Vision
II.1-II.54	Chapter 2 Planning Context and Proposed Ohio River South Shore Trail (ORSST) Alignment
III.1-III.25	Chapter 3 Phasing, Estimate of Probable Costs and Financing
IV.1-IV.5	Chapter 4 Ownership, Operation, and Maintenance
A.1-A.3	Appendix A Sample Intergovernmental Agreement
B.1-B.X	Appendix B Design Guidelines



Executive Summary

Project Background

The Ohio River South Shore Trail (ORSST) Feasibility Study represents a unique effort to physically connect eight municipalities located in two counties, along the southern edge of the Ohio River. The ORSST is part of a larger trail corridor that includes up to twenty-six (26) Western Pennsylvania Communities. The communities within the ORSST Feasibility Study include: Monaca Borough, Center Township, the City of Aliquippa, Hopewell Township, South Heights Borough, Crescent Township, Moon Township and Coraopolis Borough. The ORSST corridor roughly parallels today's CSX Railroad's mainline corridor from Pittsburgh to Ohio and follows the former Pittsburgh & Lake Erie Railroad's mainline.

The Ohio River Trail Council (ORTC) is an organization that was formed to advocate for the creation of a multi-use trail along the Ohio River and is one of the key partners in the promoting this study effort. The City of Aliquippa, on behalf of the eight South Shore municipalities, and in partnership with Beaver County and the ORTC, took the lead in obtaining a Pennsylvania Department of Conservation and Natural Resources Community Conservation Partnership Program (C2P2) grant to fund the undertaking

of the ORSST Feasibility Study. Matching funds were obtained through contributions, both monetarily and through in-kind services, by each of the participating municipalities.

The ORSST Feasibility Study builds upon the tradition of community based planning that has been led and promoted by Beaver and Allegheny Counties, as well as all of the eight communities within the study area. Beaver and Allegheny Counties have recently completed major regional planning efforts that address trail planning elements as well as parks, recreation, open space preservation and the protection and improvement of the Ohio River.

Project Vision

The Ohio River Trail will be a great asset and wonderful addition to the region. It offers important recreational, health, tourism, and economic benefits to local and regional residents. The trail will help to stimulate the development of new businesses as well as tourism-related opportunities like river rafting or canoe tours, bicycle sales and rentals, restaurants and lodging. It will become a highly desirable recreation destination, which will help to attract and retain businesses, residents (including young families) to the region.

Ohio River Trail Vision Statement:

The communities of: The City of Aliquippa, Monaca Borough, Center Township, Hopewell Township, South Heights Borough, Crescent Township, Moon Township and Coraopolis Borough will all be interconnected by a contiguous linear trail spine that links these communities with local and regional trail networks in an effort to support each community's initiatives to promote economic development, expand transportation options, provide additional recreation opportunities and enhance the overall quality-of-life for all residents.

Project Goals:

Goal #1: Establish the Spine - Establish a dedicated linear trail, paralleling and located as close to the Ohio River as possible, from the existing Montour Trail to the Monaca Rochester Bridge crossing in Monaca Borough.

Goal#2: Maximize the Overall Potential Community, Transportation and Economic Impact - Design a trail in a manner that best serves the needs of regional users, businesses, employers, and property owners.

Executive Summary

Goal #3: Make Physical Progress in Both the Short and Long Terms - Determine the most viable route for a linear trail or network of trail segments that can be implemented within the shortest period of time and identify the preferred ultimate alignment, that can be created over time.

Goal #4: Develop a Bicycle and Pedestrian Friendly Culture throughout Each of the Communities - Identify a trail feeder system of on-street bicycle and pedestrian connectivity in order to maximize the ability of local residents to access the trail and the riverfront and also provide a means for regional users to reach local businesses, destinations and attractions.

Goal #5: Reconnect the Community to the River's Edge - Utilize the trail as an impetus for a regional greenway network of diverse publicly accessible lands, parks, recreation facilities and historic and cultural activity settings/sites along the Ohio River -i.e. make the Ohio River edge as publicly accessible as possible within each community and as a linear greenway network, while balancing the needs for preserving existing and future redevelopment.



The Ohio River's Edge in Center Township

Proposed Trail Route

As a method to divide the overall ORSST corridor into manageable pieces for detailed study, the corridor was divided into six segments denoted as 100 through 600. For each segment a series of alternative routes were identified for further study through fieldwork and based on public input. The various alternatives are described in detail and a preferred ORSST route is identified. The following is brief summary of the preferred route by segment.

Section 100 – Monaca Borough

The proposed ORSST route starts at the Monaca Rochester Bridge, travels along 9th Street to Washington Avenue. It travels along Washington Avenue to 16th Street. The route travels along 16th Street towards the Ohio River to Indiana Avenue. At Indiana Avenue the route travels along a public alleyway located behind the Monaca Memorial Field complex to the edge of the Ohio River where it turns to travel underneath the Monaca East Rochester Bridge. The route travels along the edge of the PennDOT right-of-way for the bridge to an alleyway located at the eastern terminus of Indiana Avenue at the rear of the Moor Industrial Park. From the terminus of Indiana Avenue, the route travels through the perimeter of the Moor Industrial Park to Pennsylvania Avenue. At Pennsylvania Avenue the route travels along the frontage of the Moor Industrial Park to Industrial Park Road at the approach to the PA Route 51/Pennsylvania Avenue Bridge over the CSX Railroad mainline. The route travels along the railroad side of Industrial Park Road, through the Beaver Industrial Park, to the Borough of Monaca/Center Township Municipal Line.

Total Length of Section 100 = 2.4 miles

Section 200 – Center Township - Hopewell Township - City of Aliquippa (West Aliquippa Neighborhood)

The proposed ORSST trail route through Section 200 would extend from Center Township/Monaca Borough Municipal Line to Section 200/300 break line just east of 7th Street in West Aliquippa. The trail through this section will consist of a continuous 10' wide side path with a 3'-5' wide planted buffer along the railroad side of Woodlawn Road.

Total Length of Section 200 = 1.5 miles

Section 300 – City of Aliquippa

The proposed ORSST trail route through Section 300 would parallel existing or future Woodlawn Road from the BCED property at the eastern portion of West Aliquippa to the Hopewell Township Municipal Line with South Heights Borough, near the Ambridge Aliquippa Bridge. The trail will consist of a continuous 10' wide side path with a 3'-5' wide planted buffer along the railroad side of Woodlawn Road.

Total Length of Section 300 = 3.3 miles

Section 400 – Hopewell Township - South Heights Borough - Crescent Township

The proposed ORSST route through Section 400 will extend from a 10' wide sidepath located along a reconstructed Woodlawn Road in the City of Aliquippa from Section 300, to North Street in South Heights Borough. At

the location where North Street travels underneath the CSX Railroad right-of-way, via a curved roadway and underpass, the trail would cross North Street to the river side of the roadway. From this point the trail would travel through a series of privately owned parcels via a new 10' wide multi-use path to the area of the existing Power Plant Road Bridge. It is believed that the trail could be located on a former rail siding roadbed that once served the Power Station in this location. From this point it would extend to Section 500, via right-of-way acquired from CSX on the Ohio River side of the existing railroad tracks.

Total Length of Section 400 = 1.4 miles

Section 500 – Moon Township

The proposed route through Section 500 would travel from Shouse Park in Crescent Township to Thorn Run Road in Moon Township via a 10' wide path through the U.S. Army Corps of Engineers (ACOE) Dashiels Lock Complex, CSX and Moon Township properties and then via a Duquesne Light utility corridor to Moon Township/Coraopolis Borough Municipal Line near Thorn Run.

Total Length of Section 500 = 2.5 miles

Section 600 – Coraopolis Borough - Moon Township to the Existing Montour Trail Milepost "0"

The proposed route through Section 600 would travel from Moon Township/Coraopolis Borough Line at Thorn Run Road to the existing Montour Trail Mile Post "0" in Moon Township, via American Bridge Way, 3rd Avenue Right-of-Way (vacant), Watt Street, Birch Avenue, Kendall Street, 1st Avenue, Broadway, Pine Alley, Montour Street, and the Montour Junction/Sports Legacy Foundation Property. The proposed trail is predominately a signed on-road route through the Borough of Coraopolis with a 10' wide multi-use trail connection at Montour Street to the existing Montour Trail, through the Montour Junction/Sport Legacy Foundation property.

Total Length of Section 600 = 2.1 miles

Phasing

Realizing that the improvements identified in this plan collectively represent approximately \$5M to \$6M in new infrastructure investments in 2010 dollars, it is important to consider how individual projects can be organized to make the overall implementation of the project manageable. An important consideration when developing the phasing strategy is the desire to maximize overall connectivity along the ORSST route as quickly as possible. The key to this strategy is the utilization of the existing Penn-

sylvania Bicycle Route A as the current bicycle and pedestrian spine. This existing on-road route allows for individual projects to occur while providing a connector route for the overall trail corridor. This also allows for the accommodation of the disconnected trail segments as portions of the proposed ORSST route are constructed in the locations where it differs from the Pennsylvania Bicycle Route A.

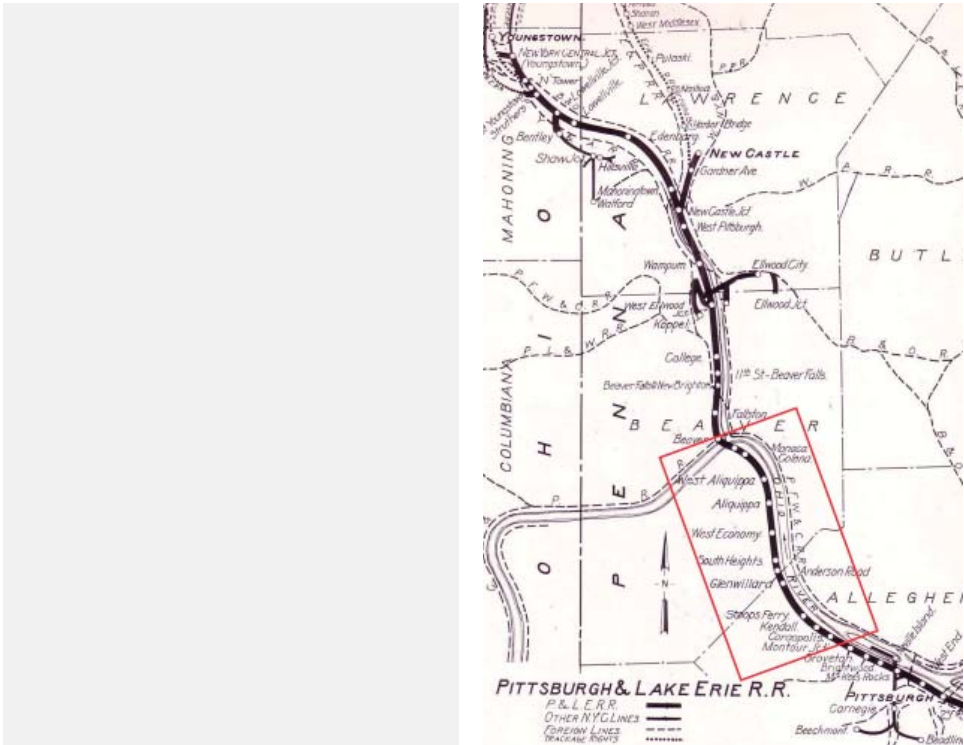
Chapter III of the Feasibility Study provides an itemized list of projects and in some cases sub projects, organized into separate phases to be achieved within a 10 to 15 year completion horizon.

Ownership, Operation and Management

While this project focuses on the eight ORSST communities, it is important to consider the ultimate trail, as a whole, when considering management, operations and partnerships strategies. By establishing an effective and creative approach to management rooted in collaboration, additional partners and resources can be folded in as the trail is extended. The eight communities within the South Shore Feasibility study area span two counties, Beaver and Allegheny, and have a combined population of over 75,000 and range in population size from 542 to 22,290 residents. The level of municipal staffing, budget and capacity for maintenance and operations vary widely by jurisdiction. By working together in developing, operating and maintaining the Ohio River Trail, the municipalities will be able to develop and operate the trail as a premiere recreation facility that will be an important asset of the region.

As one of the leaders of the ORSST study effort, the ORTC is a non-profit corporation well suited to serve as the umbrella organization for the management of the ORSST. Already in place with a positive public image, the ORTC could help to carry out the intergovernmental agreement for the trail development and operation. The ORTC already provides a management foundation to the municipalities in the trail corridor in terms of getting it up and running. The ORTC could serve in a leadership role in all facets of trail planning, development and operation in the corridor, thereby providing expertise and support that the municipalities may not have on their own.

A sample intergovernmental agreement for the ORSST communities is provided in Appendix A of this document and is intended to be used as a model to further partnership discussions.



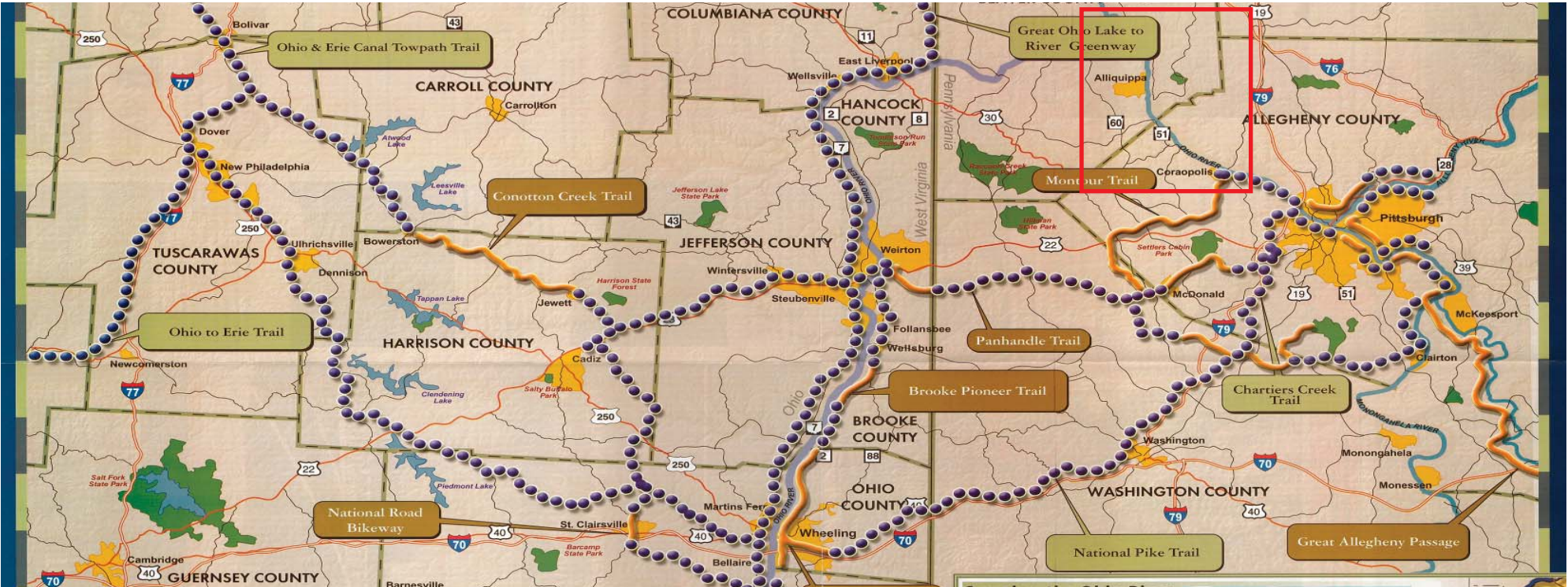
Project Background, Public Planning Process and Vision

Project Background

The Ohio River Trail Council (ORTC) proposes a multi-use trail, the Ohio River Trail (ORT), along the “La Belle Riviere” or the Ohio River and its tributaries from West Virginia and Ohio to Beaver and Allegheny County, Pa.

The Ohio River Trail Corridor is located in the foothills of the Appalachian Mountains and includes up to twenty-six (26) Western Pennsylvania Communities. There are eleven North Shore communities and nine South Shore communities. There are also four communities included in the North Shore extension and two in the Brady’s Run Extension.

The communities within the Ohio River Trail South Shore Trail (ORSST) Feasibility Study includes eight of the nine overall South Shore communities: Monaca Borough, Center Township, the City of Aliquippa, Hopewell Township, South Heights Borough, Crescent Township, Moon Township and Coraopolis Borough. The ORSST corridor roughly parallels today’s CSX Railroad’s mainline corridor from Pittsburgh to Ohio and follows the former Pittsburgh & Lake Erie Railroad’s mainline.



The ORTC proposes to interconnect existing trails in the tri-state area such as The Great Ohio Lake-to-River Greenway, The North Coast Inland Trail, The North Bend Trail, The American Discovery Trail, Brooke Pioneer Trail, Wheeling Heritage Trail, The Beaver River Trail, The North Country National Scenic Trail, The Montour Trail, The Chartiers Creek Greenway, The Three Rivers Heritage Trail, The Great Allegheny Passage, The Erie to Pittsburgh Trail, and The Pittsburgh to Harrisburg Mainline Canal Greenway (Millennium Legacy Trail) thereby creating a comprehensive interlinked mega-trail system.

The ORTC is in support of a growing national movement to develop greenways, especially since 1987 when President Reagan’s Commission on American Outdoors recommended establishing a national greenways network. Greenways are often accomplished and managed through partnerships between municipalities, counties, and non-profit organizations. Pennsylvania’s statewide Greenways Program was established by Pennsylvania Governor Tom Ridge in 2001 to promote and support the many local and regional greenway efforts in all 67 counties. The vision is to create a network of greenways throughout the Commonwealth, with a greenway in every community by 2020.

The City of Aliquippa, on behalf of the eight South Shore municipalities, and in partnership with Beaver County and the ORTC, took the lead in obtaining a Pennsylvania Department of Conservation and Natural Resources Community Conservation Partnership Program (C2P2) grant to fund the undertaking of the ORSST Feasibility Study. Matching funds were obtained

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The ORSST Feasibility Study builds upon the tradition of community based planning that has been led and promoted by Beaver and Allegheny Counties, as well as all of the eight communities within the study area. Beaver and Allegheny Counties have recently completed major regional planning efforts that address trail planning elements as well as parks, recreation, open space preservation and the protection and improvement of the Ohio River.

Beaver County’s 2010 Comprehensive Plan and its 2007 Greenways and Trails Plan establish strong goals and recommendations that support the planning, design and implementation of new trails throughout the County. These recommendations set the framework for the ORSST Feasibility Study effort.

Allegheny County, Places is the County’s 2008 Comprehensive Plan and is the County’s first comprehensive plan. The plan established an overall vision for the County’s future and series of policies and actions to achieve the vision. The plan’s unifying theme is supporting and enhancing “places” throughout the County through quality-of-life improvements. The plan specifically promotes the development of extensive greenways to connect communities with parks, trails, riverfronts and other natural amenities. In addition, *Allegheny’s Riverfronts, A Progress Report on Municipal Riverfront Development in Allegheny County, 2009*, is a report prepared as a joint effort between Allegheny County, Friends of the Riverfront and the Pennsylvania Environmental Council. The document examines the diverse riverfront community development opportunities that exist, including ways to balance the industrial needs of the region’s rivers with the potential to provide continual access along the four rivers in Allegheny County. It also explores the goal of providing positive non-motorized recreational experiences on and along the rivers, especially the Ohio River.

Public Planning Process

Community Participation

The trail planning process included a series of public involvement activities as part of the overall ORSST Feasibility Study preparation. The community input and education for the ORSST Feasibility Study was conducted primarily through steering committee meetings, key person interviews and two public meetings, as well as through a municipal leaders/stakeholders targeted survey and a project website managed by the Ohio River Trail Council.

Project Steering Committee

The project steering committee includes representative members from each of the eight municipalities as well as from other key public agencies and major stakeholder groups. Many of the members of the steering committee are also active in other local or regional planning efforts and provided valuable insight and direction throughout the planning, alternative review and recommendation development process.

Public Meetings

The first public meeting was a public open house and presentation held on March 10th, 2010 at the Community College of Beaver County Learning Resource Center in Center Township. The goal of this meeting was to introduce the project to the community and interested stakeholders, obtain feedback on the proposed project vision and goals and determine potential route alternatives to study.

The second public meeting was a public open house held on April 14th, 2010 at the Moon Township Municipal Building. The open house format of this meeting consisted of a series of information stations grouped by the six trail

planning sections established to aid in the organization of data, analysis, alternative evaluations and proposed trail recommendations. Meeting attendees were provided the opportunity to comment and physically mark-up drawings and maps at each work station as a way to record all community comments, concerns, ideas and areas where more information was needed. The outcome of this meeting, along with feedback from the project steering committee, resulted in the proposed Ohio River South Shore Trail route presented in Chapter 2 of this document.

Municipal Leaders Survey

A four page survey was distributed to elected officials, key staff and other identified stakeholders. The survey questionnaire included questions which gauged the current status and need for trails and other parks, recreational, open space and multi-modal transportation facilities and resources within each respective municipality. The survey also asked each respondent to assess their community’s desire for the creation of new trails within their community and the region, as well as their willingness to support, including economically, the construction of a trail along the Ohio River as well the expansion of public access to the river. The results of this survey were partly used to develop trail route recommendation as well as the ownership, management and maintenance recommendations presented in Chapter 4 of this document.

Ohio River Trail Project Website

The Ohio River Trail Council maintains a project website which allows all interested parties access to information on the Ohio River South Shore Trail Feasibility Study as well as providing project updates and meeting notices. It can be viewed at: www.ohiorivertrail.org.

Vision Statement and Project Goals

Ohio River Trail Vision Statement: The communities of: The City of Aliquippa, Monaca Borough, Center Township, Hopewell Township, South Heights Borough, Crescent Township, Moon Township and Coraopolis Borough will all be interconnected by a contiguous linear trail spine that links these communities with local and regional trail networks in an effort to support each community’s initiatives to promote economic development, expand transportation options, provide additional recreation opportunities and enhance the overall quality-of-life for all residents.

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SCALE: Not to Scale